

A YEAR ENDS, A REIGN ENDURES

Years reset, champions don't. Dvalishvili's run has become less about victory than about the quiet **inevitability** of his will.

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The final numbered event of 2025 in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) has all the ingredients to be one of the year's best.

At the top of UFC 323 main card, the Bantamweight Championship rematch between champion Merab Dvalishvili and former champion Petr Yan is a contest of validation versus vengeance.

Dvalishvili continues to cement his legacy through relentless activity and dominant wins over top contenders, turning his reign into an iron-fisted era. If successful in his fourth defence, he would become the first UFC champion to record four title defences in a single year.

For Yan, who has clawed back from a three-fight slide, this bout is an all-or-nothing bid for redemption. His insistence that he was not at his best in their first encounter makes this main event a pivotal test of his resurgence. A loss here could permanently close the door on his championship future.

The Flyweight co-main event offers a classic veteran-versus-rising-star narrative. Alexandre Pantoja has been nothing short of a world-beater, extending his win streak to eight while defending his belt with consistent dominance.

Pantoja exemplifies a battle-tested champion. Since capturing the title from Brandon Moreno in December 2023, he

has been on a tear, defending it four times and extending his overall win streak to eight. His style is defined by unrelenting, high-pressure offence.

Opposite him stands Joshua Van, a 24-year-old pocket rocket who has compiled an impressive 8-1 record since joining the promotion.

At just 24, Van's rise has been fuelled by youthful hunger and rapid progression. He has faced and passed every test quickly.

This fight will reveal whether his raw talent, momentum, and pace can overcome Pantoja's championship experience and veteran control. Van enters with little to lose and everything to gain, making him a dangerous and unpredictable threat.

Also announced on the card is a

Raw exultation: Merab Dvalishvili roars in triumph after retaining his bantamweight title, his trademark intensity on full display inside the Octagon following another dominant performance. GETTYIMAGES

light heavyweight match-up between former champion Jan Blachowicz and Bogdan Guskov.

Blachowicz is chasing his first win since May 2022, following a split draw with Magomed Ankalaev in their title fight two years ago and subsequent decision losses to Alex Pereira and Carlos Ulberg.

Did you know?

The record for the longest winning streak in the UFC bantamweight division belongs to Georgian powerhouse and current champion Dvalishvili, who has notched up an extraordinary 14 straight victories.

This remarkable run includes wins over multiple former champions such as Yan, Jose Aldo, Henry Cejudo, and Sean O'Malley.

His dominance not only makes his streak the longest in the division but also places him among the all-time greats in UFC history. Overall, he ranks fourth for the longest win streak, with the legendary Anderson Silva topping the list at 16.

Nicknamed "The Machine", Dvalishvili also holds the UFC record for most career takedowns landed, underscoring the tireless energy and volume he brings to every fight.

